

AI.WOMEN Hackathon – Participant Handbook

1. Welcome

1.1 A note to welcome you

Welcome – we're so glad you're here.

For two days, this is your space to explore, experiment, and build with AI. Whether you've been shipping models for years or you're opening an AI tool for the very first time, you belong in this room. There's no baseline you need to have reached, no skill level you're expected to prove. Curiosity and effort are what count here – not polish, not perfection, and definitely not being the best coder in the room.

This isn't primarily a competition to win against each other. It's a weekend to build something you're proud of, alongside people who want to see you do it. Take the chance to try the thing you've been curious about, ask the questions you've been sitting on, and meet women who are figuring it out right alongside you.

Let's build, together!

1.2 About AI.WOMEN

AI.WOMEN is an initiative by [Petra Vorsteher](#) and [AI.GROUP](#) that brings together women working with Artificial Intelligence, exploring AI use cases, or beginning their journey into the field. The initiative creates spaces for meaningful exchange, practical insights, and supportive networking across roles, disciplines, industries, and levels of AI experience. AI.WOMEN is built on the belief that in order to help each other better we need to know

each other better, and that AI should be discussed, developed, and applied by diverse voices.

1.3 About the Hackathon

The AI.WOMEN Hackathon is two full days for women to actually build with AI – from a first prototype to an ambitious project. It's community-first and hands-on: less talking about AI, more building with it. The community has grown fast through our AI.WOMEN Circle events, and the Hackathon is the natural next step – giving women the space, time, and support to create and build with AI together.

1.4 How to use this handbook

Read the essentials (#2) and *Before you arrive* (#3) now, so you arrive ready on Saturday, 12 September. Come back to the schedule (#5), *Fair Play* (#9), *What to submit* (#10), and *Judging* (#11) during the weekend when you need them. If a question isn't answered here, §13 tells you who to ask.

2. The essentials at a glance

2.1 When

Saturday 12 September, 09:00 – ~22:00/22:30

Sunday 13 September, 09:00 – ~19:30

Doors open at 09:00 on both days. These are family-friendly hours – there's no overnight building; each day winds down and everyone heads home.

2.2 Where

Kühne Logistics University (KLU) – our official Location Partner. [KLU](#) is a private, English-taught university on the waterfront in Hamburg's HafenCity, with a modern campus looking out over the Elbe and the harbor. → [Maps](#)

Getting there is simplest by U-Bahn: the nearest stop is **Überseequartier (U4)**, about a 3-minute walk from campus. Coming in on the U1 or U3? Change to the U4 at Hauptbahnhof, or walk 10–15 minutes from Meißberg (U1) or Baumwall (U3).

3. Before you arrive

3.1 Create your participant profile – Step 1

Please set up your official participant profile. It's a **two-step process**: the first step creates your profile record, and you'll then get an email with a link to a more detailed form for step two. (Allow a few minutes for that email, and check your spam folder if it doesn't arrive.) It's an important part of how we organise the weekend, and it feeds the team-matching process so you and your fellow builders can get to know one another beforehand.

Please complete your profile by **Wednesday, 9 September** at the latest.

>> [Set up Your Participant Profile here](#) <<

3.2 Say 'Hi' in Slack

Once your profile is done, you'll get a separate invitation from Slack to join our AI.WOMEN Hackathon workspace – your space to connect before the event. Four channels are waiting for you:

- **General** – the main channel for event updates in the run-up
- **Q&A** – ask us anything before the weekend
- **Travel Buddies** – for anyone travelling in from outside Hamburg, or offering a place to stay
- **Find Your Team** – introduce yourself, share your idea or skills, and start forming teams

3.3 Find your team

You don't need to arrive with a team, and you don't need to be a coder. In the **Find Your Team** channel, you can post a short intro, see who else is coming, and connect with people

whose ideas or skills click with yours. We've put together a short guide with two ready-to-use intro templates and a few tips for building a great team. And if you haven't found your people by the time we start, there's a dedicated team-finding session on Saturday (see §6).

[>> Read the Find Your Team Guide here! <<](#)

3.4 What to bring

- Your laptop and chargers
- If you plan on building a mobile app, please also bring a mobile device
- Any tools or hardware you want to build with and already are subscribed to
- A reusable water bottle and a (to-go) coffee mug (to help us cut down on waste)

3.5 Dietary needs

We collect dietary requirements as Step 2 of your participant profile – please make sure yours are filled in so we can plan catering accordingly. We can only plan for dietary needs that are in your profile, so if you haven't registered your participant profile and filled it out properly, we cannot promise to be able to cater to yours.

3.6 Travel and accommodation

Coming from out of town? A few things that help:

- We've gathered hostel and hotel options close to the venue in a separate overview.
→ [Where to stay in Hamburg](#)
- Use the **Travel Buddies** channel on Slack – some participants are looking to share accommodation.
- We start at 09:00 on Saturday, so it's worth arriving in Hamburg the night before.
- Local with a couch or spare room to offer? We'd love it – community helping the community.

3.7 The night before: Warm-Up Meet & Mingle (Fri 11 Sep)

We're kicking off a night early, and you're warmly invited. Together with our community partner **HADLEY's**, we're hosting a relaxed warm-up the evening before the Hackathon — a chance to meet the people you'll be building alongside all weekend. No agenda, no pressure.

- **When:** Friday, 11 September, 17:30–19:30 – come whenever suits you, and you're welcome to stay on afterwards.
 - **Where:** HADLEY's Bar, Beim Schlump 84A, 20144 Hamburg ([Maps](#))
 - **Drinks** are on a self-pay basis.
 - So we know how many to expect, please register via the separate Luma event: <https://luma.com/z0n0vq4v>
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4. Arrival & Check-in

4.1 Getting there and doors open

Doors open at **09:00** on Day 1 at KLU (see §2.2 for the address and U-Bahn directions).

4.2 Check-in and opening

At check-in you'll pick up your name badge and settle in. Saturday's program starts at **09:45 with the official opening**: a welcome and short intro to the two days, an introduction to our partners, and what to expect over the next two days.

Check-in will be sorted alphabetically by First Name.

5. The two days – Agenda

5.1 Day 1 – Saturday, 12 September

Getting started: arriving, get-to-know the AI tools in hands-on sessions, forming teams, and building into the evening.

Time	What's happening
09:00	Participant Arrival & Check-In
09:45 - 10:00	Official Opening & Welcome
10:00 - 10:30	Organizational Event Info
10:40 - 10:55	15 Min Hands-On Sessions by Tool Partners (Round 1) • Bilt – An Estonian platform that lets you build real mobile apps just by chatting with AI, so anyone with an idea can create a mobile app without knowing how to code. • Anymize AI - A GDPR-compliant AI workspace that automatically anonymizes sensitive data – names, IBANs, dates, case numbers – before it ever reaches a model like GPT, Claude, or Gemini, then restores the originals in the answer, so you can build with real data safely. • HeyGen – Create polished AI videos with lifelike avatars and voiceovers straight from a script. • (more sessions TBA)
11:00 - 11:15	15 Min Hands-On Sessions by Tool Partners (Round 2) • Bilt – An Estonian platform that lets you build real mobile apps just by chatting with AI, so anyone with an idea can create a mobile app without knowing how to code. • Anymize AI - A GDPR-compliant AI workspace that automatically anonymizes sensitive data – names, IBANs, dates, case numbers – before it ever reaches a model like GPT, Claude, or Gemini, then restores the originals in the answer, so you can build with real data safely.

	• HeyGen – Create polished AI videos with lifelike avatars and voiceovers straight from a script. • (more sessions TBA)
11:15 - 11:45	Coffee Break
11:45 - 12:00	Hands-On Session by Dr. Janet Brinz on Codex by OpenAI • Codex – OpenAI's AI coding agent that reads your codebase and writes, fixes, and ships code for you, so you can build features by describing what you want instead of typing every line.
12:00 - 12:15	Hands-On Session by Ksenia Nekrasova on Google Cloud • Google Cloud – Google's cloud computing platform, offering the infrastructure, data tools, and AI models (including Gemini and Vertex AI) that teams use to build and run applications at scale.
12:15 - 12:20	Intro To Team Finding Session
12:20 onward	Supported Team Finding Session for everyone without a final team
12:20 onward	Teams that are already complete (3 to 5 people) can register with organizers and start working on their Idea
13:15	Working Lunch
13:30 onward	Teams work on their projects and ideas
18:30	'AI.WOMEN Hackathon Pizza Party' Powered by Mercedes-Benz AG  Mercedes-Benz Hamburg
21:00	One more hour to go!
~22:00	Day 1 comes to an end, See you tomorrow morning!

5.2 Day 2 – Sunday, 13 September

Bringing it home: teams finish, the best teams present, an all-female jury reviews the work, and we close the weekend together.

Time	What's happening
09:00 onward	Participant Arrival & Check-In
10:00 - 10:20	Info Session for Team Leads or a Team Delegate – “How to hand in your project” (Mandatory)
10:20 onward	All Team Members return to their teams & continue building
13:00	One hour to go until Handing In your Projects
13:00/13:30	Working Lunch
14:00	Hand-In/Submission Deadline for all projects
14:30	Half-Final Line-up Announcement
14:45	Half-Final – all teams pitch on four stages (all teams, 3-minute pitches)
16:30–16:45	Half-Final wraps up; teams gather in the networking area while scores are tallied
17:30	Announcement of the Top 12 Teams for the Final
18:00	AI.WOMEN Hackathon Final – the top 12 teams pitch on the main stage (3 minutes each)
19:00	Award Ceremony
19:30	AI.WOMEN Hackathon Reception & Networking
~20:30 - 21:00	AI.WOMEN Hackathon 2026 Comes to an End

5.3 Food & Breaks

Meals, snacks and drinks are provided across both days – including light lunches, a Pizza Party powered by Mercedes-Benz on Saturday evening, and a reception with snacks on Sunday evening, after the award ceremony. Please register your dietary needs via your participant profile (§3.5).

6. Teams

6.1 Team size and how teams work

Teams are **3 to 5 people**. The best teams bring together a mix of skills and experience levels – you don't all need to code, and you don't all need to do the same thing. A first-timer and a seasoned engineer on the same team isn't a mismatch; it's exactly the kind of pairing that makes the weekend valuable for everyone.

6.2 The team-finding session

If you arrive without a team, join the **moderated team-finding session at 12:30 on Day 1** in the Networking Area. Introduce your idea or your skills, meet others, and form a group around a shared curiosity. All teams register with the organizers before building begins. We will share more information on how to register your team with the organizers on the day of the event.

6.3 What a good team can look like

There's no fixed formula, but teams tend to work best when a few different strengths come together. Think of these as things a team needs – not job titles you have to qualify for, and one person often wears several hats:

- **The idea driver** – keeps the team connected to *why* you're building this and who it's for.
- **The builder(s)** – comfortable with code, tools, or data; turns the idea into something that runs. Often two people, not one.

- **The product manager** – keeps everyone on track over the two days: what to build first, what can wait.
- **The designer/storyteller** – shapes how the project looks and feels, and how you'll explain it.

What matters is that everyone brings *something*, and that you use each other's strengths.

>> [Read more about Teams & finding a team here.](#) <<

6.4 Find a Team or an Idea

To help you connect before the weekend, we've created two overviews from everyone's participant profiles:

- **Participant overview** – everyone taking part, with their profiles, so you can see who's coming and find people you'd like to build with. → [Participant Overview](#) (Password: "aiwomenhckthn26")
- **Ideas overview** – all the ideas people shared in their profiles, so you can browse for a project that speaks to you, not just a teammate. → [Idea Overview](#) (Password: "aiwomenhckthn26")

So whether you're looking for the right people or the right idea, there's a place to start. You'll also find everyone in the **Find Your Team** Slack channel, and there's a team-finding session on Saturday if you'd rather meet people in the room.

7. AI Mentors

7.1 What mentors are there for

Experienced female AI mentors are on the floor all weekend as sparring partners. Pull one in to pressure-test an idea, talk through an approach, get unstuck, or find the right tool or technique. They're here to help you move forward.

7.2 What mentors won't do

Mentors never take over. The project always stays your team's own – they'll help you think, but the building is yours.

7.3 Meet the AI Mentors

You can find an overview with all AI Mentors here. (Use the password "aiwomenhckthn26")

>> Meet the AI Mentors <<

8. Our partners

The people and companies helping make this weekend happen.

8.1 Your tool stack – Tool & Token Partners

You'll have real tools, credits and support to build with. The current confirmed stack – and of course you're free to use other tools too, so if you already have accounts with tools you love, bring them along.

- [**Google Cloud**](#) – cloud infrastructure and the Vertex AI platform for building and running AI and Agents, including the Gemini models.
- [**OpenAI**](#) – frontier AI models (GPT) for text, reasoning, images, and more.
- [**Bilt**](#) – build native mobile apps from a plain-English description.
- [**Anymize AI**](#) – AI data anonymization: detects and replaces sensitive data before it's sent to an AI model, then restores it in the response.
- [**HeyGen**](#) – AI video generation with lifelike avatars and voiceovers.
- [**Echelon AI**](#) – an AI workforce for enterprise IT service platforms: builds, maintains and optimises catalog items, flows, apps, and tests.
- [**ElevenLabs**](#) – AI voice: realistic text-to-speech, voice cloning and audio generation.
- [**PRIOR \(Prior Labs\)**](#) – TabPFN, a tabular foundation model: go from tables (like a CSV) to predictions in minutes, with zero training.
- [**n8n**](#) – workflow automation you can self-host: wire tools and AI together in a visual builder.
- [**Langdock**](#) – an enterprise AI platform: chat, workflows, and agents across leading models.
- [**Firecrawl**](#) – turn any website into clean, LLM-ready data (crawling, scraping and search).
- [**Featherless AI**](#) – Serverless hosting that gives you one API key and instant access to 40,000+ open-source models, so you can run and switch between any model without setting up your own infrastructure.
- [**Beyond Presence**](#) – real-time conversational AI video avatars.
- [**Make**](#) – visual automation to connect apps and AI into workflows, no code required.

8.2 Our Corporate Supporters

A thank you to our Corporate Supporters – [Beiersdorf](#), [Mercedes-Benz](#) Hamburg, and [Gebr. Heinemann](#) – companies rooted in Hamburg whose support helps make the Hackathon possible, and to [KLU Kühne Logistics University](#) for being our official location Partner!



Mercedes-Benz Hamburg



8.3 Community Partners

Reaching more women together with our community partners: [AI Curious Collective](#), [PANDA | The Women Leadership Network](#), [Hacker School](#), [GermanTechJobs](#) and [Hadleys Bar](#).



THE WOMEN
LEADERSHIP NETWORK

HADLEY'S



9. Fair Play Guide

This weekend isn't about being the best coder, the best pitcher, or the most polished team. It's about genuinely engaging with AI, making real progress, and being able to explain what you built and why. Here's what fair play looks like:

- **Effort and curiosity are the win.** Genuine engagement and real progress over two days matter more than polish. A simple, well-understood project can score just as well as an ambitious one.
- **Build it here.** Your project should come together over the two days – only projects started fresh at the event can be submitted and evaluated for judging. Your public GitHub repo and its commit history are part of what you submit, so let the work show its own journey.
- **Be honest about how it works.** Judges may ask how something was built – that's completely normal, not suspicion. Being clear about what's AI-powered versus hardcoded is always the right move, and clarity is rewarded far more than the illusion of complexity.
- **Unfinished is fine.** A rough demo, a partial repo, a deck with open questions – all of it counts, and every submission is read carefully whether or not the team presents live.
- **Mentors are sparring partners.** Lean on them as much as you like – but the project stays your team's own.
- **Show up for your team.** Both days are a commitment. A team that loses a member partway through is left short, which makes it less rewarding for everyone in the group.
- **Keep it a respectful space.** This is a supportive space, and it works best when we welcome each other the way we'd like to be welcomed. Be warm, be generous with your time and knowledge, and treat everyone here – teammates, mentors, organizers and fellow participants – with respect and kindness.
- **Be mindful with the internet.** We're sharing one network among many people. Be considerate with bandwidth so everyone can keep building.
- **Be mindful with power.** Sockets are shared too. Bring your own charger, share outlets, and switch off what you're not using.
- **We're guests.** We're hosted at KLU this weekend. Let's treat the space with care and leave it as good as we found it.

10. What to submit

Due by **14:00 on Day 2**. More information will follow prior to and on the day of the event.

- Public **GitHub repo** with README and event commit history
 - **Demo recording** of the project in action
 - Short **slide deck**
 - **One slide** with a screenshot of what you built, a logo, and a claim (for future social use)
 - A **one-pager** describing the project and which tools you used
 - **Optional:** a hosted preview URL
-

11. Judging

11.1 Judging philosophy

We're not looking for the next unicorn, a flawless product, or the most polished pitch. We're looking for genuine engagement with AI, real progress over the two days, and a team that can clearly explain what they built and why. The same criteria apply to every team – a simple, well-understood project can score as well as an ambitious one.

11.2 The judging categories

Every judge scores independently across **five criteria**, each from **1 (Just Getting Started)** to **7 (Outstanding)**. The scale recognizes progress at every level.

- **Problem & Idea Clarity** – 20%
- **Meaningful Use of AI** – 25%
- **Execution & Product** – 20%
- **Creativity & Originality** – 20%
- **Collaboration & Communication** – 15%

The full breakdown – what each criterion means, what a good pitch looks like, and what every score means – is in the judging overview:

>> [Read more on "How Judging Works"](#) <<

11.3 How the pitches and scoring work

Each team gives a short **3-minute pitch**, and judges may ask a few friendly questions afterward (in the final on mainstage). Every judge scores independently on their own card; scores combine across the panel. It runs in two rounds – a Half-Final across four stages (from 14:45) and a Final on the main stage for the top 12 teams (from 18:00).

11.4 The jury

An all-female jury drawn from the AI.WOMEN community, partners and sponsors. The line-up is announced closer to the event.

12. Awards

12.1 The "AI.WOMEN Hackathon Award" – Overall Top 3

Awards celebrate the standout teams of the weekend, including the overall top three.

12.2 "Best use of..." Tracks

Several of our Tool & Token Partners each host and judge a "best use of" award for their tool:

- Best use of **Bilt**
- Best use of **HeyGen**
- Best use of **anymize.ai**
- Best use of **Google Cloud**

12.3 The Final on the main stage

The top 12 teams pitch on the main stage before the award ceremony (see §5.2).

12.4 The AI.SUMMIT 2026 Invitation

The best 3 teams (AI.WOMEN Hackathon Award) are invited to **AI.SUMMIT 2026 – Corporate Edition**, AI.GROUP's flagship annual event, on **24 November 2026 at CCH – Congress Center Hamburg**. It's a full day of applied AI with 1,000+ decision-makers, founders and practitioners, 50 AI startups, and 40+ sessions across three stages – a chance to share what you built with a much wider audience.

More about AI.SUMMIT 2026 here: www.ai.hamburg/ai-summit-2026

13. Good to know (logistics)

13.1 WiFi and power

We'll share WiFi details with participants on the day.

13.2 On-site help

Look for the organizer desk and our team on the floor – we're easy to spot and happy to help with anything during the event.

14. Contacts

Questions any time: **ai.women.hackathon@ai-group.ai**. On-site, find an organizer or mentor on the floor – we're here for you all weekend.

Plans changed? If anything comes up and you can't join, a quick heads-up to the address above means we can offer your spot to someone on the waitlist.